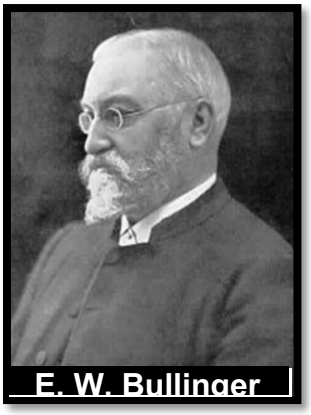
9. Figures of Speech

Figures of speech are a normal and natural part of our language and bring colour, life and feeling to our written and spoken language. Yet, if wrongly understood, they can lead to miscommunication and misunderstanding. Being able to recognise a figure of speech and understand how it works is as important to the interpretation of scripture as it is to any other literature.

In his book titled, *Figures of Speech Used in the Bible, Explained and Illustrated,* E. W. Bullinger identifies 217 different figures of speech some of which have 30 to 40 varieties in about 8,000 instances in Scripture! No, we are not going to study this area in this kind of depth, but rather I want to introduce you to some of the most common figures of speech and how they work. I do commend Bullinger's book as a good study companion when you are more familiar with the Bible study process.



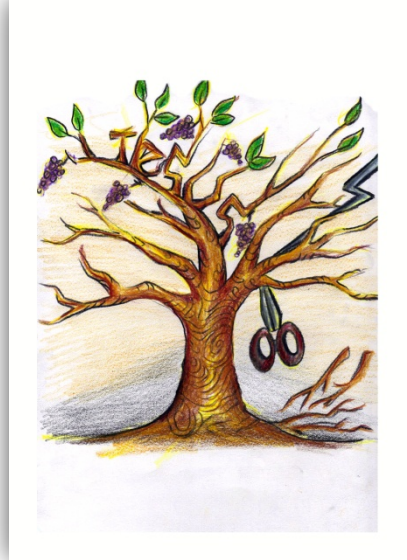
For some, you may find this lesson a little technical but be patient, do your best to identify and understand each of these Figures of Speech as you are able and, as we proceed with our studies, you will quickly learn how to observe them and they will become familiar to you.

A figure of speech is a literary device in which words are used out of their literal sense in order to suggest a picture or image. Identifying and understanding figures of speech is simply seeking to identify the author's intended meaning, which is one of the goals of inductive study.

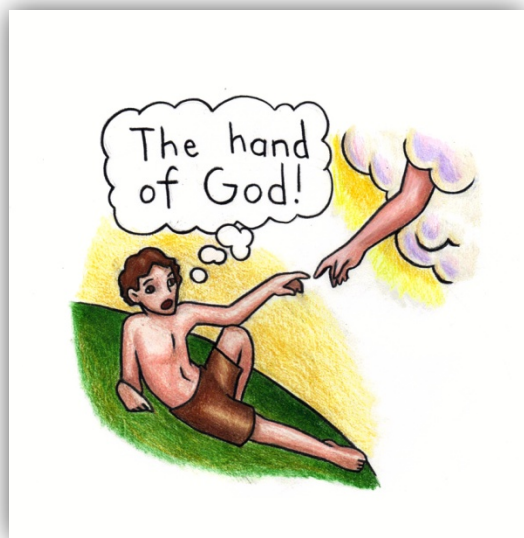
We should note that each figure of speech is not a watertight compartment, but there are at time overlap on the type of figures and their usage.

Analogy

An Analogy is where there is a comparison, showing points of similarity. For example, a common analogy is made between a heart and a pump. In the Bible we often see an analogy between God who is the shepherd and his people that are the sheep. In John 15:1-9 we have the well known analogy of Jesus being the vine and believers being the branches.



Anthropomorphism



Anthropomorphism is when human form and attributes are assigned to God. In Psalm 10:12 God is entreated to “lift up your hand”, while in Psalm 44:3 the victory was not of human doing but by the “right hand and arm” of the Lord. In Psalm 33:18 it is the “eye of the Lord” that is on those that fear him while in Genesis 19:29 we read the comforting words that God “remembered” Abraham during the judgment of Sodom.

Apostrophe

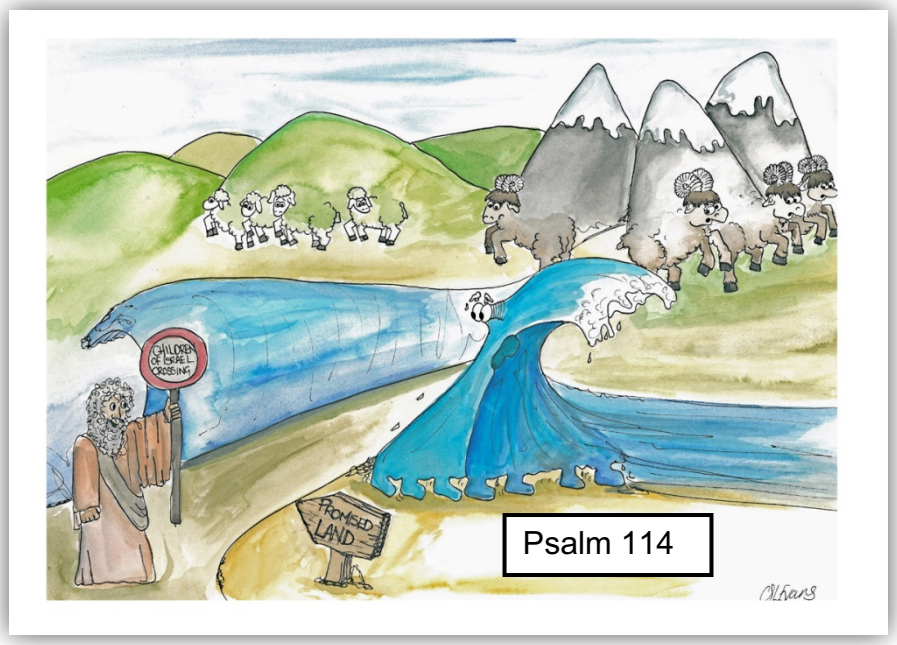
Apostrophe, when used in the context of figures of speech, is not referring to the punctuation mark that is so often forgotten or misused today, but rather a term that refers to addressing some absent or nonexistent person or thing as if present and capable of

understanding. It is addressing or speaking to things, abstract ideas or imaginary objects.

Paul Simon in *The Sound of Silence* uses this device when he sings:

"Hello darkness, my old friend
I've come to talk with you again . . ."
(Paul Simon, "The Sounds of Silence")

Thousands of years before Paul Simon, Moses uses this device in his hit song in Deuteronomy 32:1 where he sings "Give ear, O heavens, and I will speak, and let the earth hear the words of my mouth". In Psalm 114 we have some humorous and vivid examples of this device where the Red Sea "looks and flees, and mountains skip like rams", and in 1 Corinthians 15:55 the Apostle brings this glorious chapter on the resurrection to a close looking death straight in the eye and demands, "O death where is your victory? O death where is your sting?"



Psalm 114

Euphemism

A euphemism, which is from the Greek "use of good words", is when an expression that may offend or suggest something unpleasant to the receiver is changed to an agreeable or less offensive expression. We are very familiar with this today in many of our cultures when the toilet becomes the "*bathroom*", "*restroom*", *"loo*" or "*outhouse*". In public life we *have big-boned* for fat, *industrial action* for strike; *misspoke* for lie and *lukewarm* for half-hearted.

In Genesis 4:1 we read that Adam "knew" Eve his wife which is an insightful euphemism for having sex, and in Genesis 15:15 Abraham would "go to his fathers", a euphemism for death. In Judges 3:24 King Eglon was said to be, "covering his feet" a polite way to say using the toilet, and Peter in Acts 2:39 declares the promise was to, "all who are afar off," avoiding the potentially offensive word of "gentiles".

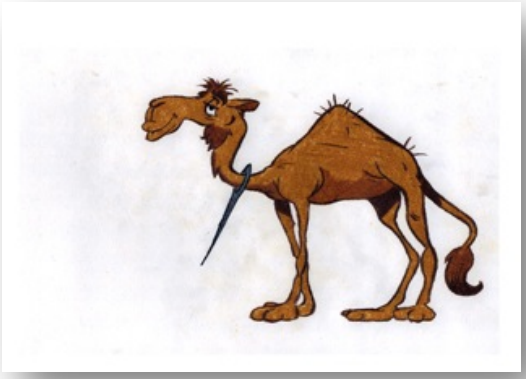
Hyperbole

Hyperbole, from the Greek word meaning “excess” is the use of exaggeration or overstatement which may be used to emphasise a point, evoke strong feelings or to create a lasting impression, but is not meant to be taken literally or intended to deceive. Also, it may be intended as a means of humor. “Always” and “every” are often words we use when we speak with hyperbole.

Jesus said it was better to enter into the Kingdom of God without a hand, foot or eye than be cast into the fire of hell. Cut them off or tear it out was his solution. It is safe to say Jesus was not preaching self-mutilation but rather making a strong statement of the seriousness of dealing with sin. The Apostle Paul’s recollection of the love of the believers in the churches of Galatia was such that they would have gouged out their eyes and given them to him.

Idiom

An idiom is an expression belonging to a particular language, often with a meaning that cannot be guessed from the actual words. So, “A diamond in the rough” indicates someone whose good qualities are hidden and “I’m broke is someone without any money.



Idioms are used in Scripture as in any language, as in Matthew 13:31. In teaching about the Kingdom of God, Jesus likens it

to a grain of mustard seed, which he says is the smallest of all seeds. Jesus was using the mustard seed in an idiomatic way, not as a botanist; it is well known that there are many seeds smaller than a mustard seed. The camel through the eye of the needle was another idiom indicating something that was impossible but also bringing in humor.

Irony

Irony is a rhetorical device which implies something different and even the opposite of what is stated. It can be used as a means of humour or sarcasm, but the point is to emphasise an assertion of truth so the hearer will be forced to consider what was said.

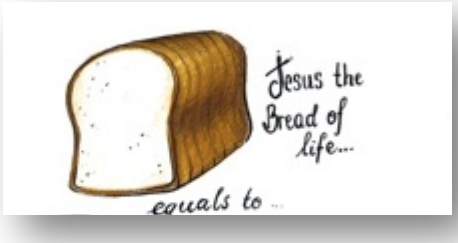
The Apostle Paul uses this devise in trying to get the proud and self-sufficient Corinthian believers to understand their need to grow from spiritual children to adults when he declares on 1 Corinthians chapter 4, “Already you have all you want! Already you have become rich! Without us you have become kings! And would that you did reign, so that we might share the rule with you!”

Litotes

Litotes is the use of understatement to make an emphasis. It is the opposite of hyperbole and is often used as irony. We might say that someone is “not unattractive”, or something is “not bad”.

We read in Acts 27:20 that Paul and his companions were in “no small storm.” And in Acts 15 how Paul and Barnabas had “no small dissension and debate” with the men who traveled from Jerusalem to Antioch.

Metaphor



A metaphor is an often-used figure of speech where there is a direct comparison between two things. It expresses the unfamiliar in terms of the familiar, and asserts that one thing is another. It is like a simile, but the connectives "like", "as" or "so" are left out.

In Psalms 91:2, we discover that "God is my rock", where in Psalm 84:11 he is our "sun and shield." In Matthew 5:13 the disciples, "are the salt of the earth" and then," the light of the world." In the Gospel of John, Jesus is (among other things) the "Bread of life", the 'way' and the "door".

Allegory

An Allegory is the rhetorical strategy of extending a metaphor through an entire narrative so that objects, persons, and actions in the text are equated with meanings that lie outside the text. Even though an allegory can be presented in a painting or sculpture it is often conveyed in a story form. Some popular examples are: Bunyan's Pilgrim's Progress, and C. S. Lewis' Screwtape Letters and Chronicles of Narnia.

In Scripture we find the story told by Jotham about the trees looking for a king in Judges 9, and in Galatians chapter 4 :22ff the well-known allegory of the two sons of Abraham, one of the slave woman and one of the free.

Metonymy

Metonymy is a figure of speech in which a thing or concept is not called by its own name, but by the name of something with which it is closely associated. For example in my country of the United Kingdom we talk about “Westminster” when referring to the Government because it is located there, and “crown” when talking about the Queen.

In Deuteronomy 28 the blessing of God is said to be upon the “basket and kneading bowl”, when it was the abundant harvest which was really in view, and in the story of the rich man and Lazarus, the rich man was told that his brothers had “Moses and the Prophets whom they should hear”, meaning the written scriptures. Circumcision and Uncircumcision are term often used to talk about both the Jews and Gentiles in the letters of Paul.

Paradox

A Paradox is a statement or group of statements that are seemingly absurd or self-contradictory but which are actually true. The term comes from the Greek meaning “incredible, contrary to opinion or expectation”. Mother Teresa said, “I have found the paradox, that if you love until it hurts, there can be no more hurt, only more love.”

Jesus in Matthew 16:25 states a life-changing paradox, “For whoever would save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his

life for my sake will find it", as does Paul in 2 Corinthians 12:10 when he declares "For when I am weak, then I am strong."

Personification

Personification is when an inanimate object or abstraction is given human qualities or abilities. The Grim Reaper personifies death and the proverb, "Fear knocked on the door. Faith answered", does the same with both fear and faith. Companies love to use this device in the promotion of their products, for example the advertising slogan for Oreo cookies, "Oreo: Milk's favorite cookie."

This is a fairly common device that is used in scripture. In Psalms 77:16 the waters are afraid, whereas in Proverbs wisdom is portrayed as a woman. In Psalm 114:4 the mountains skipped like rams, the hills like lambs.

Rhetorical question

A rhetorical question is a question posed for its effect without the expectation of a reply. The purpose of the rhetorical question is to encourage the listener to think about what the answer to the question must be. The answer may be obvious or immediately provided by the questioner. Both Jesus and the Apostle Paul used this device quite extensively.

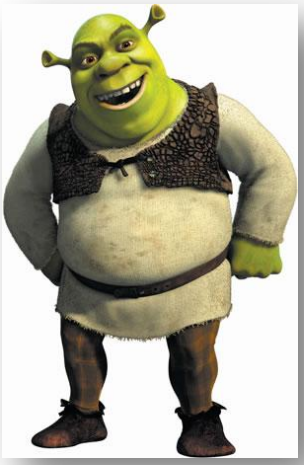
When affirming the provision of the Father, Jesus asks:

- Is not life more than food and the body more than clothing?
- Are you not of more value than the birds?
- And which of you by being anxious can add a single hour to his span of life? (Matthew 6:25-26)

Simile

A simile compares two different things indirectly by employing the words "like", "as", or "than". Even though similes and metaphors are both forms of comparison, similes compare the two ideas and allow them to remain distinct in spite of their similarities, whereas metaphors compare two things directly. As with all of these forms of figures of speech, when a comparison is being made it is not all the points of similarity that are intended.

So, in the movie ‘Shrek’ Ogres, he says, are like onions, but not completely:



Shrek: For your information, there's a lot more to ogres than people think.

Donkey: Example?

Shrek: Example... uh... ogres are like onions!

[*holds up an onion, which Donkey sniffs*]

Donkey: They stink?

Shrek: Yes... No!

Donkey: Oh, they make you cry?

Shrek: No!

Donkey: Oh, you leave 'em out in the sun, they get all brown, start sproutin' little white hairs...

Shrek: [*peels an onion*] NO! Layers. Onions have layers. Ogres have layers. Onions have layers. You get it? We both have layers.

[*walks off*]

Donkey: Oh, you both have LAYERS. Oh. You know, not everybody like onions. What about cake? Everybody loves cake!

In Psalm 1:3-4 the righteous are like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season, and its leaf does not wither. In all that he does, he prospers.

Whereas in Matthew 7:24 those that both hear and do what Jesus teaches is like a wise man building on the Rock, but those that just hear and do not do, are like the foolish man that builds his house on the sand.

Synecdoche

This last figure of speech that we are going to consider is called Synecdoche. This derives from the Greek meaning “shared or simultaneous understanding”. It is when a part is used to represent the whole or the whole used to represent the part. In contemporary usage we talk about “wheels” meaning the whole vehicle, and when we ask someone to “give us a hand” we want more than just a hand!

In the Old Testament it is not unusual for the whole ten tribes of the Northern Kingdom to be addressed by the name of the leading tribe, Ephraim, as we find repeatedly in Isaiah chapter 7. In Genesis 3:19 Adam is told, “By the sweat of your face you shall eat bread, meaning all that he would eat, not just bread.

In writing about “flesh and blood” the writer of Hebrews means, of course, physical people, as does Paul in Ephesians when he declares “we do not fight against flesh and blood”, Ephesians 6:12.